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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Study Interrupted

by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

Adora is trying to study for her biology finals. Her friends think that she should take an evening to unwind, and Catra volunteers to be the one to convince her.

Chapter 1: Pop Quiz

Exams were the bane of every bad student, and the nightmare of the good. One wrong move, one spelling mistake, could cost exponentially more once it was factored into the larger equation. For some, this was an unbeatable menace that could be ignored, safe in the knowledge that no amount of studying could overcome poor luck, stress, or simple human error. At the far end of the spectrum were the students that would spend every spare minute working to cram their minds with knowledge, honing their skills and practicing until their memories of home had been overwritten with facts and theories.

Somewhere on the far side of those people was a blonde student currently working through a collection of flashcards thicker than her ponytail was long.

"What is the difference between aerobic and anaerobic dissimilation?" Adora read from her card before sparing a second to process the question. "Aerobic has oxygen, anaerobic does not, thus making it less efficient as the glucose can't be fully broken down with the presence of oxygen." She flipped the card over, checking the answer she had written on the back. A perfect recital. She was even smug enough to have included a pretentious 'thus'.

A rapid knocking at her door interrupted her concentration. "Hey Adora!" A familiar voice called from behind the wood. "Come on, I know you're in there."

Adora ignored the voice, swapping to the next card.

"What kind of effect can anaerobic dissimalation have on the human body?" The sound of more knocking interrupted her thought process for a moment as she tried to recall the answer. "Acid buildup, oxygen deprivation, and potential lactic acidosis?" She flipped the card, mentally cursing the intruder at her door.

"*Lactic* acid buildup." A minor oversight that would still cost her marks.

A sharp beeping at the door cut through her attention.

"Hey Adora," Catra leaned casually against the doorframe, keycard dangling innocently between her claws. "What'cha doing?"

"*Studying*." Adora grumped, turning back to the desk. "Does Glimmer know that you've got her keycard?" The dorms she was paying a small fortune for were supposed to be safe from the cold-callers, solicitors, and occasional attempted burglar. Of course, none of it worked if students kept lending out their keycards to be borrowed by their friends.

"How else would I have gotten my hands on it?" She strode in like she owned the place, tail tracing across Adora's shoulders as she passed. "Come *oooon*," Catra whined, sprawling messily across Adora's formerly pristine bed. "Even Princess Sparkles has managed to get her head out of her arse for the evening."

"*Glimmer* finished her exams last week," Adora snapped. It was a sore point that the physics exams finished earlier than the rest of the sciences. At least she could take solace from the fact that she would be finished nearly three hours before the chemistry courses, but was fuming that Glimmer and Bow were happily free to swan about without a single care in the world. "And I think you picked art just because you can get through on coursework alone."

"That, and I get to stare at my favourite model whenever I want." Catra grinned, leaning up on one arm. Adora's expenses were being partially covered by picking up odd jobs for the university. It was strange to find out that doing jobs directly for the educational facility paid nearly triple the rates they would in the real world but only because they were applied as discounts against her existing fees. Technically, the university wasn't paying her, and thus didn't have to pay taxes or any of the million other legal rings they would have to jump through. Of course, being a live model for

some of Catra's classes wasn't the most well-paying jobs, but that wasn't necessarily why she had picked up the role.

"Domain, kingdom, phylum, order, class, family, genus, species." Adora recited listlessly as she forced herself to focus once more on her studying. "Species, genus, family, class, order, phylum, kingdom, domain."

"Overworking, brain, you." Catra insisted. "Need, break, one, night, out!"

"I'm reciting the taxonomic ranks from most to least inclusive, and then least to most." Adora checked the back of her card to confirm the answer. It was nearly correct. She swore, grabbing a textbook and flipping to the page in hopes that she had copied it wrong. "Domain, kingdom, phylum, *class*, *order*!" She wailed, face planting into the soft embrace of the pages. "Class, order. Class, order." She recited angrily in smothered mumbles.

"Head up," The book was ripped from beneath Adora's face before it had barely risen off the surface. "You're burning yourself out trying to make sure every question is perfect," Catra scowled. "You don't have to get all of them right, just enough."

"Says *you*," Adora grabbed the book back. "We can't all be expressive and applauded."

"Hey, as long as it works!" Catra snapped back. Her methodology had been criticised multiple times by the faculty, but they couldn't argue that her works were amongst the most evocative to come out of the university in years. She'd already managed to sell a couple to interested buyers. Whilst at ludicrously low rates compared to other works of her calibre, her novice status meant that she was still available for commission.

Her ruthless demeanour also meant that she refused to work for anything less than her worth, and she was already saving for a life after graduation.

"Look, you're reciting everything backwards and forwards, right?" Catra offered the textbook back as a peace offering. "Let me take a swing at reading those cards to you, you do the answering, and give your eyes a rest."

"I'm fine." Adora insisted, knowing that the cheap textbook was blurry from poor ink.

"Then you're saying that not interacting with other people is the best way of studying?" Catra perched on the edge of her desk with a pointed glare. Adora was the one who went out of their way to organise study groups, and extracurriculars, and tutoring arrangements.

Scowling, she lifted the cards in offering, and let her tired muscles relax her face into the wooden laminate.

"Genetic information is transferred from nucleus to cytoplasm by way of?" Catra dangled the question hesitantly.

"RNA?" Adora groaned into the desk.

"Yeah, I don't know what that is?" Catra reminded her.

"Ribonucleic acids." Adora unabbreviated the term she had printed on the back of the card.

"Ribbo… Righbow…" Catra stumbled over the unfamiliar pronunciation. "Looks close enough." She shrugged, and shuffled the card to the bottom of the pack. "Why, Adora," She grinned teasingly over the next card. "You naughty girl."

"What?" Adora lifted her head in confusion.

"The term *phallus* refers to the structure of what sort of organism?" Catra smirked.

"Brown algae!" She snapped, face growing to match her hoodie. "And it's pronounced *thallus*!" Catra glanced at the card again.

"Nah," She shuffled the question randomly into the deck. "True or false: the mitochondria is the powerhouse of the cell."

"Give me those!" Adora reached for the cards, lunging as Catra stretched them back with a laugh. "You're not helping me study!" She wrestled with her friend, trying to get back to protecting her future career as they collapsed backwards onto her bunk.

"Hang on," Catra laughed, fighting back. "You get one full run-through of these cards with no mistakes, I'll kiss you full on the mouth and admit that I was wrong about you wasting all your time studying."

"What?" Adora blurted, aware of how their legs were slotted together as she strained over the painter, both heaving with exertion.

"Come on," Catra goaded. "You'll get to say 'I told you so' all the way until graduation, and we both know how much you like being right."

The biology student contemplated the deal for herself. "One round?" She demanded.

"Winner takes all," Catra clarified. "If you get more than one wrong, you have to come out for an hour, have a drink with your friends, and chill out for an evening."

High stakes. But Adora was no coward.

"You're on." Dragging her chair over, she watched Catra cross her legs beneath her with impossible flexibility, tail swishing over the bed as she gathered the stack of cards.

"What form of external growth is used for both support and protection?"

"Exoskeleton," Adora shot back. "Insects are typical examples of exoskeletons in practice, as are molluscs. Endoskeletons are

internal in creatures such as people, and birds." Catra glanced at the back of the card, pupils narrowing.

"Lucky guess." She scowled, tossing the question aside.

"Hey!" Adora glared, picking it up to place on the desk at the end of the bed. The room she shared with Glimmer was efficient, if slightly cramped no matter where they tried to be. With a desk at the foot of their beds, and a cabinet beside them, it was difficult not to hit something when stretching. "They're grouped by subject." She insisted.

"Whatever," Catra rolled her eyes, returning to the next question. "Which organelle is responsible for breaking down and recycling cellular waste and debris?"

"Lysosome." Adora shrugged. "Find a hard one next time." Her interrogator hissed menacingly, baring teeth in a feral growl. Adora didn't fall for the taunt, merely growling back herself.

"Two het-ero-zyg-ous?" She raised a questioning eye to Adora, who nodded in response. Faith restored, Catra reverted to her scowl. "Parents for tongue rolling," The scowl flickered briefly before resuming. "Have a child. What is the chance of their child *not* being able to roll their tongue?"

"One in four." Adora said encouragingly. She knew that Catra didn't like to feel underprepared, especially when going into an unfamiliar subject that included words she didn't know.

"What is the primary function of amylase?" She forced her brain not to say 'mayonnaise' at the last moment.

"Breaking down of carbohydrates." Adora responded easily. Too easily for Catra to buy it.

"You wish," Catra flipped the card to check the answer with an easy grin. "Waste of a wish." She grumbled, leaning over to put the card on the desk as her smile faded.

It went on in that fashion, Catra asking the questions, Adora easily answering them. As she relaxed, her mind was freed up to notice other facts. Like how Catra was wearing her favourite shirt, a dark blue one a few sizes too big, that hung off her like a dust sheet loosely draped over a work of art. Or how it had a few new splotches of paint since the last time she had seen her wear it, thin streaks near the rolled cuffs. Colours that matched the subtle eyeline which accentuated her natural look.

"Last question," Catra tapped the final card uneasily, knowing that Adora had been able to see the last answer since the start. "True or false, the mitochondria is the powerhouse of the cell?"

"True." Adora smirked. Like every other question before it, she nailed the answer.

Catra scowled, flipping the card under her knees and refusing to answer. "Ha!" Adora snapped, snatching the card away as she leaned intimidatingly over her friend. "I *told you so*!"

"And I admit that I was wrong about you wasting all your time studying." Catra grinned, unphased by the looming figure.

The cards were suddenly back in her hands, and Adora didn't mind because Catra had leaned up, and softly pressed her mouth to Adora's with a happy rumble purring through their lips. "Hey Adora?" She breathed, eyes closed. "You willing to play another game?"

"Um," Adora bit her lip. She had won already, she could get back to studying, Catra would leave if she was asked to. "What sort of game were you thinking?"

"Do or die round," Catra smirked, shuffling the cards back into a rough pile. "You game?"

"Try me," Adora narrowed her eyes. "What are the rules?"

"Simple," Catra goaded, rifling through the cards to pick one out at random. "One win, one kiss. You get one answer wrong, I

never shut up about it."

"Deal." Adora would probably have agreed to any stakes after she heard the first part.

"DNA, or deoxyribonucleic acid," Catra easily rolled the words off her agile tongue this time, showing that she had been paying attention the entire first round. "Exists in what form?"

"Double strands of DNA," Adora swallowed uneasily as she answered. "Coiled around each other." A list in the back of her mind knew that DNA looked like twisted ladders, composed of sugar molecules and a phosphate group connected by a nitrogen base.

That thought was overwhelmed by the soft pressure against her mouth, conflating with how Catra's tongue was wrapping around hers.

"Benefits of long-term anaerobic dissimilation?" Catra groaned quietly, glancing at a card as she wrapped an arm around Adora's shoulders and pulled her down against the crumpled sheets.

"Higher resistance to lactic acid," Adora murmured, pinning Catra's hands to the bed, and tugging the cards from her grasp. "Allows harder work for longer."

"Yeah?" Catra's tail was curling around her hips as she tugged Adora in, legs slotting between each other as she reached up to pull the hair tie out. Her hair cascaded down around them, cutting off the rest of the universe behind a shimmering golden curtain. "How much longer?"

Adora didn't answer with words.

Chapter 2: Crunch Time

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a final exam to sit. Unfortunately, her friends' plans are having repercussions.

Adora was forced awake as her wrist vibrated. *Fuck!* Her watch was her emergency alarm, for if she somehow slept through her first two! Craning her arm, she forced brunette hair out of her way to check the time.

Half past seven.

Assuming that she spent ten minutes getting breakfast, fifteen minutes showering, five minutes cleaning her teeth, five minutes getting dressed, ten minutes getting ready for the day, twenty minutes on the commute, ten minutes getting through registration for the exam, half an hour revising her materials before bags were stored away, then she was already fifteen minutes late!

She was also aware that she wasn't a brunette.

"Mngh." Catra murmured, nuzzling against her chest.

Adora's heartbeat exploded into life without caffeine, instantly propelling her to full alertness. Why was Catra here? Why was she…

Events flooded her brain, and Adora cursed her good recall and bad reaction to stress. There was time to worry about that later.

Scowling angry thoughts, she fumbled away from her encumbrance, and awkwardly stumbled onto what was generously referred to as the 'open space' between her bed and Glimmer's. From there, she grabbed her towel from a hook, crammed herself into a bathrobe, snatched her washkit, and sprinted to the showers.

Whoever had reservations about communal wash facilities was weird by Adora's standards - everyone went into their own cubicles and locked the door, so what was the big issue? Also, the water pressure was *perfect*, and she could probably make coffee in the shower if she turned the heat all the way up. Rumour had it that Kyle had tried making instant noodles that way, but forgot to remove the packaging from the flavour packet - the resulting hospital trip had cost him three days and his reputation.

Shower done, she blazed through her room in a frenzy of hair drying as she crammed a protein bar through her jaw, and grabbed her toothbrush before disappearing back to the washrooms again. She looked as unbalanced as she felt, frantically scrubbing behind a resistant molar to extract the last wedge of gruel.

Task complete, she ran back to her room, frantically pleading that Catra remained asleep. "Can you keep it down?" She murmured in an achingly enticing way. "Some of us are trying to nap."

Adora silently threatened whoever had been ignoring her earlier pleas as she grabbed the first clothes that came to hand that her brain didn't clock as belonging to Glimmer and cramming herself into them. Perching on the edge of the bed to pull her shoes on, her whole body froze as Catra's tail softly traced from hand to elbow before curling away again.

Moment over, she grabbed her backpack, and lunged for the door. "Hey," Catra murmured softly against her stolen pillow. "Good luck with the exam." Adora gave no reply, stomping out of her room and wishing that the stupid mechanism didn't catch it at the end and stop it from slamming. Catra hummed contentedly, wriggling around in the bed as she returned to her nap.

Twelve minutes (and a stop at the university cafe so fast that the bewildered barista behind the counter wasn't entirely sure it hadn't been some sort of weird robbery) later, she skidded around a corner and headed to the hall at the end.

"You're the only one who gets here this early." Huntara groaned, swinging back in her chair.

"Gives me more time to get in the right headspace." Adora panted, holding up her university ID with one hand as the other braced against her knee.

"It also means that *I* have to get up earlier," Taking the card, Huntara made an exaggerated display of checking it against her list of candidates. "I could be in bed right now, snuggled up with someone warm, cuddly, maybe a cute, furry art student," She shrugged, uncaring of Adora's explosive blush as she handed the card back. "But I'm sure your priorities are in the right place."

Adora hurried into the hall, ignoring the callous laughter behind her, and found her seat. Digging out her notebook, she began aggressively cramming as she inhaled the banana and coffee from the cafe.

A few other faces drifted in early like she had, but she didn't notice until a familiar one forced itself into her perception.

"Real subtle." Lonnie smirked as she slumped into the seat beside Adora.

"Maybe you'd score a bit better if you put some effort in." Adora snapped, not glancing up from her notes.

"Trust me," Lonnie leered as she waved to the incoming horde of students. "I score *plenty* as it is, I'm just not as obvious bragging about it."

"It's not 'bragging' to study." Adora scoffed.

Lonnie went the sort of suspiciously silent that would normally demand people focus on her growing smile. Adora was too far into her revision to notice, and also missed the series of hand gestures Lonnie was throwing out to indicate to everyone else what she was finding so amusing.

The exam hall gradually filled up, and Huntara eventually came in to bellow for silence, books away, and to start handing out papers. "Nice shirt." She smirked as she passed Adora's desk. Adora glanced down, and froze.

She was wearing a loose blue shirt. Coloured here and there in splotches of paint from doing an art degree - *Catra's.*

Adora was beyond mortified as she realised that *everyone* had seen her wearing Catra's shirt, and had likely correlated her dishevelled appearance with something else altogether. Grabbing her test, she silently vowed revenge on the questions it contained.

'What is the primary function of amylase?' Impossibly, the voice she heard when reading the question was the same one that had been reading it to her the night before.

"Breaking down carbohydrates." She filled the circle in desperate hopes that the haunting would be over.

'Very good.' The words purred into her ear.

Adora growled in her throat to match. "Stupid Catra, stupid Glimmer, stupid Catra, stupid Bow, stupid Catra." Lonnie glanced over in concern. She couldn't remember the last time Adora had spoken with genuine ire in her voice.

'What form of external growth is used for both support and protection?' The question mocked her in perfect imitation of Catra's tone from the night before.

"Exoskeleton," Adora scribbled her answer down in furious penship. "Insects are typical examples of exoskeletons in practice, as are molluscs. Endoskeletons are internal in creatures such as people, and birds."

'Lucky guess' The imaginary Catra scoffed.

Adora punched the table turning the page.

Being called to a professor's office was either a sign of incredible achievement or damning trouble. Adora tried to imagine that it was for good reasons. "Do you know why I've called you here?" Angella sternly asked.

"No?" A horrified realisation swept through Adora's mind. "Did I fail the final? Please, if there's any way that I can make it up, or have a redo or,"

"Adora!" Angella raised her voice commandingly. "You are here on suspicion of academic violations." Opening the folder on her desk, she withdrew an answer sheet. "You completed the test in eight minutes, and with a perfect score. I know that you have discipline, but such an achievement is unheard of. You will be resitting the exam, under a new format, to ensure that you did not have access to an advanced copy."

"I… what?" Adora sat dumbly in the chair. The tests were a mix of choice and written answers, and could be marked the same day, but it had been barely two hours since the exam finished. Huntara must have rushed it after she left suspiciously early.

"Can you offer a reasonable explanation before the university has to conduct a rigorous investigation into your past marks?" Angella's words ignited the fury that Adora had spent the morning trying to restrain.

"Maybe because I've written out all the exam questions for the past five years and studied them every day?" She snapped. "Or the flashcards that cover every fact in every textbook I've had to check out from the library since I enrolled? Or the extra sessions I've requested from every," Angella raised a patient hand to end the tirade, and appraised her for a long moment. Then, she reached out a finger to the phone on her desk. "Juliet?" She pressed the intercom. Her assistant was in the room before she even lifted her finger. "Can you please go to Adora's room and collect her flashcards?"

"My ones for today's exam are on the desk," Adora twisted uncomfortably. "And, er, maybe a few are on the floor. The rest are in a box under my bed."

"I'll be back in half an hour." Juliet reported as she noted down the locations.

"Very well," Angella called up a file on her computer. "Adora, I want to ask you questions from past exams until Juliet does so."

"Of course." Adora was eager for the chance.

"The term thallus refers to… are you alright?" Angella had been unprepared for Adora to groan and slump against her desk.

Juliet returned thirty minutes later, as promised, stumbling under the weight of Adora's flashcards. "You said they were in a 'box'," Angella stared at the container shaking her desk upon deposit. "This is a *crate*."

"It's a *box*!" Adora scowled. "You and Glimmer both say the same thing."

"Quite." Angella carefully extracted a slim pile, and began examining the contents.

"Wait outside." Juliet demanded shortly. Adora slumped into a seat outside the office as Juliet practically forced her out.

"Hey." A familiar voice uttered uneasily.

"Hey." Adora kept staring at the far wall in terror. This day couldn't get any worse.

"Nice shirt." Catra casually noted the attire as readily as one would remark on the weather.

Adora wanted to shrivel up and die as she sat beside her.

"Why are you here?" She dragged her mind to the mundane issues, like how she was facing expulsion and loss of her degree, and away from the important matters, like how she and Catra were wearing each other's clothes.

"Jules thought I might have been texting you answers because I was in your room with all your notes."

Adora groaned, knowing that this was inevitably going to weigh against her. "Why *were* you still in my room?" She demanded.

"Your bed was cozy, and smelled nice." Catra shrugged. "Also, you took my top."

"Adora!" She delayed her spontaneous death from embarrassment as Glimmer and Bow came running down the corridor.

"What are you doing here?" She automatically rose to hug them.

"Juliet called us here," Bow explained, squeezing her supportively tight. "She said that Glimmer's mom needed to ask us some questions."

The office door flew open before a face of thunder. "*I do.*" Cold eyes pinned the newcomers to seats, and returned Adora to hers.

"Adora, your excuse is that you were studying last night, and Catra can attest to that since she was there with you," Angella glared. "Catra, your excuse for being missing from your dorm last night was that you were out helping the needy." Three sets of eyes noticed the smug grin, instantly decoding the message behind it, as the fourth set avoided eye contact. "Which is very fortunate, because that would explain why Glimmer made no mention of your presence after she got back to her dorm last night," Angella glared at her daughter, wings slowly spreading dangerously behind her. "After all, her keycard was used to return to the room last night."

In all the intense focus of the night before, Adora had failed to recognise that Glimmer never made it back to their shared room

without the key card that Catra had appropriated. In which case, where *had* she slept?

Her eyes crept along the death row to where a textbook example of the panic reflex was kicking in. Most people thought it boiled down to "fight" or "flight", but there were actually *four* distinctly recognised reactions, and Bow was perfectly exemplifying the third ("freeze"), doubtless because he had spent the night before employing the fourth ("fu

"What's the problem?" Catra cut through Adora's imagination before she could mentally scar herself. "Adora works her butt off to get a perfect grade, and you're complaining that it's too perfect?"

"The *problem*, Catra," Angella glared. "Is that your stories don't match up. I would need them to do so before I can dismiss the accusations against Adora." All four students looked nervously at each other. It was an impossible situation - nobody could save Adora without betraying themselves.

Except for one person.

"Look, the thing is," Catra began.

Adora suddenly gasped, pointing down the corridor. "Is that a mouse?!"

"Where?!" Catra's fur instantly fluffed up, and the other group stared down the corridor in the direction that she was looking.

Adora wasted no time, grabbing her by the hand, and sprinting away from the tense standoff. "Trust me," She gasped. "We do *not* want to get caught in that one."

"We can hide at my place!" Catra grabbed Adora's hand right back as the shouting started behind them. "You can give me my top back." Adora stumbled, and Catra was suddenly the one pulling her forward. "You didn't plan on having anything else on today, right?"

Adora knew both meanings that Catra was implying, and found herself agreeing twice.

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